

Orbit Cafe - Franchise Handbook

1. The Brand and Franchise Fees

Orbit Cafe is a specialty coffee brand with a space-age design theme, known for its single-origin espresso and its signature Nebula cold brew. Franchisees operate under a ten-year agreement with an option to renew for a further ten years.

The initial franchise fee is 45,000 US dollars, payable when the franchise agreement is signed. This fee covers brand licensing, the opening support team and access to the operations manual.

Franchisees pay an ongoing royalty of 6 percent of gross sales, reported and paid monthly. In addition, 2 percent of gross sales is contributed to the national marketing fund, which pays for national campaigns, the mobile app and seasonal menu launches.

Franchisees may not sell products that are not on the approved menu without written approval from the franchise support office. Local specials are permitted if they use approved ingredients.

2. Opening a Store

Every proposed location must be approved by the real estate team before a lease is signed. Site approval takes up to 60 days and includes a footfall study and a review of nearby competitors. The minimum store size is 1,200 square feet of customer-facing space.

Before opening, the franchisee and their store manager complete 3 weeks of training at the Orbit Academy in Denver. Training covers espresso preparation, the point-of-sale system, food safety and local store marketing.

The opening support team spends the first 10 trading days on site. The store fit-out must use the approved design package, including the dome ceiling lighting and the star-map feature wall.

A soft opening for friends and neighbours is recommended during the week before the public launch, so that the team can practise at full volume before real customers arrive.

3. Food Safety

Refrigerators and milk fridges must hold a temperature of 4 degrees Celsius or below, checked and logged at opening, midday and closing. Any fridge reading above that limit for more than one check is reported to the store manager and the contents are assessed.

Milk that has been left at room temperature for 4 hours or longer must be discarded. Opened milk cartons are labelled with the time they were opened.

Staff wash their hands at least every 30 minutes during a shift, and always after handling cash, taking out waste or touching their face. Gloves are worn when handling ready-to-eat food.

The espresso grinders and group heads are cleaned daily at close, and the espresso machine is descaled every week. Cleaning is signed off on the closing checklist by the shift lead.

4. Quality Audits

Each store receives a mystery shopper visit twice per quarter. The shopper scores drink quality, speed of service, cleanliness and friendliness against the standard scorecard.

The passing score for a quality audit is 85 out of 100. Scores are shared with the franchisee within a week of the visit, together with photos and notes from the shopper.

A store that fails two consecutive audits must submit a remediation plan within 30 days. The regional manager then visits the store to agree the plan and schedules a follow-up audit.

Stores that score 95 or above on every audit in a calendar year receive the Orbit Gold award and a reduction in their marketing fund contribution for the following year.